

Multigrid Finite State Projection for the Reaction-Diffusion Master Equation

Aditya Dendukuri

University of California, Santa Barbara

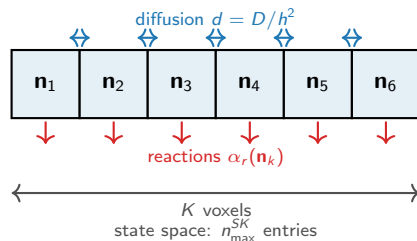
The RDME: reactions and diffusion across a spatial grid

Model. Divide a 1-D domain into K voxels. Each voxel k holds molecule counts $\mathbf{n}_k \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}^S$.

Two types of events:

- **Reactions** inside voxel k : rate $\alpha_r(\mathbf{n}_k)$, change $\mathbf{n}_k$.
- **Diffusion** between neighbors: rate $d = D/h^2$, moves one molecule $k \leftrightarrow k+1$.

The joint probability $p(\mathbf{n}_1, \dots, \mathbf{n}_K, t)$ satisfies $\dot{p} = Ap$ (**RDME**).



The computational bottleneck

The state space has $\sim n_{\max}^{SK}$ reachable states — **exponential in K** . Even $K=8, S=1$ is intractable with a naive FSP.

$\dot{p} = Ap$ has **block-tridiagonal structure** (schematic, $K=4$, $S=1$)

$$\begin{array}{c}
 \begin{array}{c} \mathbf{n}_1 \\ \mathbf{n}_2 \\ \mathbf{n}_3 \\ \mathbf{n}_4 \end{array}
 \begin{bmatrix}
 \begin{array}{c|c|c|c}
 \mathbf{n}_1 & \mathbf{n}_2 & \mathbf{n}_3 & \mathbf{n}_4
 \end{array} \\
 \hline
 \begin{array}{cc}
 A_1 & D_{12} \\
 D_{12} & A_2 \\
 \hline
 & D_{23} & A_3 \\
 D_{23} & A_3 & D_{34} \\
 \hline
 & & D_{34} & A_4
 \end{array}
 \end{bmatrix}
 \cdot
 \begin{bmatrix} p_1 \\ p_2 \\ p_3 \\ p_4 \end{bmatrix}
 =
 \begin{bmatrix} \dot{p}_1 \\ \dot{p}_2 \\ \dot{p}_3 \\ \dot{p}_4 \end{bmatrix}
 \end{array}$$

each block: $n_{\max}^S \times n_{\max}^S$ total: $n_{\max}^{SK} \times n_{\max}^{SK}$

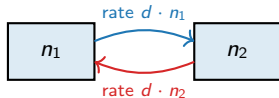
A_k : reactions inside voxel k (dense block)
count)

$D_{k,k+1}$: diffusion between neighboring voxels (sparse: shifts one count)

The Binomial is the exact diffusion equilibrium

Fix total molecules $\bar{n} = n_1 + n_2$ across two adjacent voxels.

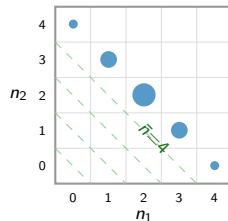
Diffusion moves one molecule at a time, at rate d per molecule:



Each molecule hops independently $\Rightarrow$ at equilibrium, equally likely to be in either voxel. For $\bar{n}$ total:

$$P(n_1 \mid \bar{n}) = \text{Bin}(\bar{n}, \frac{1}{2}) \quad (\text{exact, any } d > 0)$$

When the distribution is near this equilibrium, $\bar{n}$ **alone describes the two-voxel state.**



Probability spreads along constant-total diagonals as $\text{Bin}(\bar{n}, \frac{1}{2})$ (dot size $\propto$ mass).

The two-voxel state is captured by $\bar{n}$ alone.

Merging two adjacent voxels: restriction and prolongation

Compress ($\mathcal{R}$): exact:

$$p^c(\bar{n}) = \sum_{n_1+n_2=\bar{n}} p(n_1, n_2).$$

Reconstruct ($\mathcal{P}$): approximate:

$$p(n_1, n_2) \approx p^c(\bar{n}) \cdot \pi(\bar{n}),$$

where π is the **within-pair distribution**.

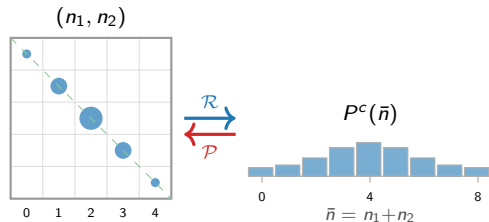
State-space reduction

Per pair: $n_{\max}^{2S} \rightarrow n_{\max}^S$.

All K voxels: $n_{\max}^{SK} \rightarrow n_{\max}^{SK/2}$.

Classical choice: $\pi = \text{Bin}(\bar{n}, \frac{1}{2})$ — exact when diffusion $\gg$ reactions.

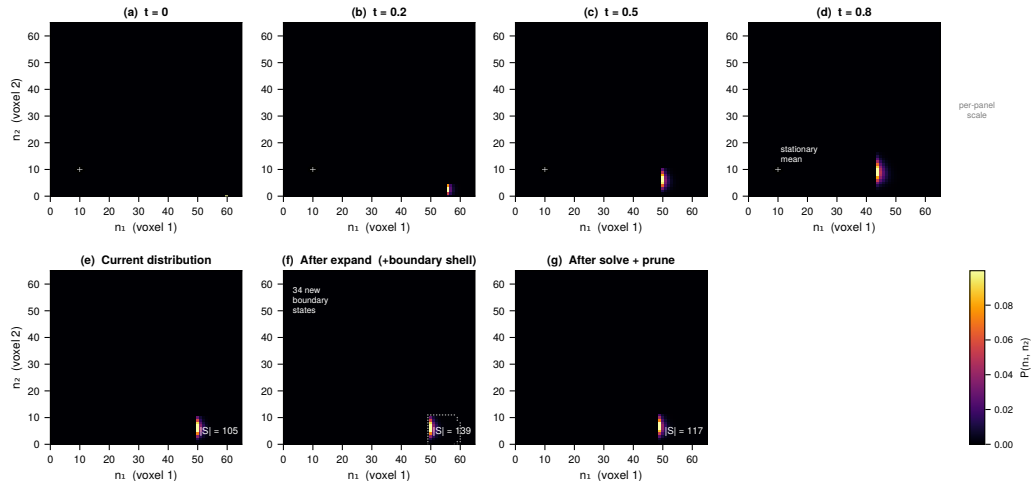
New: patch QSD (later) — exact conditional



$\mathcal{R}$: sum along each diagonal $\rightarrow$ scalar $\bar{n} = n_1 + n_2$.

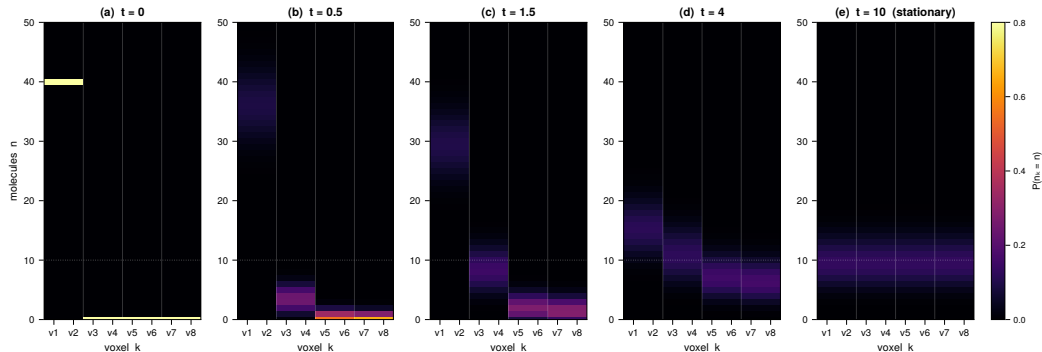
$\mathcal{P}$: spread back via within-pair distribution π .

The adaptive FSP algorithm: expand, solve, prune



Top row: joint distribution $P(n_1, n_2)$ of a 2-voxel birth-death system: point source at $(n_{src}, 0)$ traveling to the stationary point (white cross).

Result: K=8 RDME wavefront via coarsened simulation



K=8 wavefront solved via K=4 coarse FSP. Max coarse state space: 106585 states. K=8 direct FSP would be intractable (grows to 90k+ states by $t=0.8$). Fine marginals recovered analytically via $\text{Binom}(n_k, \frac{1}{2})$ prolongation — exact for balanced pairs.

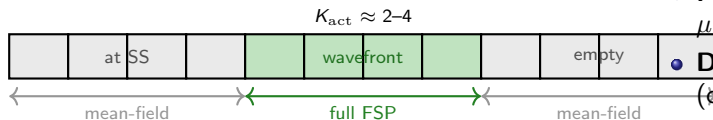
Birth-death RDME, $K=8$, $D=0.1$. IC: $v_1=v_2=40$ (delta), $v_3 \dots v_8=0$. Each panel shows marginals $P(n_k=n)$ for all 8 voxels.

(a)–(d): Wavefront sweeps left→right, distributions broaden. **(e)**: Stationary: all voxels reach Poisson(10) (dashed line).

Solved via **K=4 coarse FSP** (30k states). Direct K=8 FSP: intractable. Fine marginals recovered via $\text{Bin}(\tilde{n}, \frac{1}{2})$:

Mixed resolution: only the wavefront needs fine tracking

Key observation: at any time t , the probability distribution has *three* spatial zones:



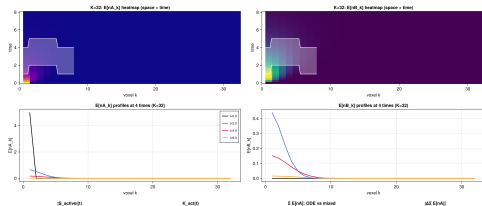
- **At steady state** (behind front): $P(\mathbf{n}_k)$ is near-Poisson(μ_{ss}) $\Rightarrow$ mean-field μ_k is sufficient.
- **Empty** (ahead of front): $P(\mathbf{n}_k) \approx \delta_0 \Rightarrow$ mean-field $\mu_k \approx 0$.
- **Wavefront:** full joint FSP on K_{act} voxels. $K_{\text{act}} \ll K$, independent of K .

State-space bound

$$|S_{\text{active}}| = O(n_{\text{max}}^{2SK_{\text{act}}}) \text{ regardless of } K.$$

Adaptive active set:

- **Promote** voxel to FSP when $\mu_k > \theta_{\text{promote}}$ (wavefront arriving).
- **Demote** to mean-field when $\mu_k \approx \mu_{\text{ss}}$ (converged) or $\mu_k \approx 0$ (empty).
- Mean-field ODE for inactive voxels — *exact for linear reactions*.
- Hard cap $K_{\text{act}}^{\text{max}}$ prevents blowup for fast diffusion.

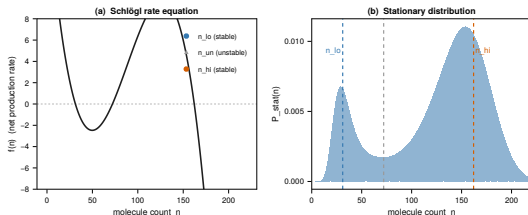


Bistable reactions

For birth-death, each voxel has one stable state.
Diffusion wins: the pair is always well-mixed.
Binomial coarsening is *essentially exact*.

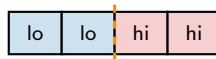
But what if reactions are bistable?

The **Schlögl model** has two stable states per voxel:
 $n_{lo} \approx 31$ and $n_{hi} \approx 162$.



Spatial metastability

Neighbors can occupy *different* states. A **spatial front** forms.



Reactions “pull” voxels apart; diffusion “pulls” them together. When reactions are fast, the front **persists for very long times**.

Why Binomial prolongation fails

Failure mode 1: bistable front (Schlögl)

The joint distribution $P(n_1, n_2)$ is **bimodal**: mass at (n_{lo}, n_{hi}) and (n_{hi}, n_{lo}) .

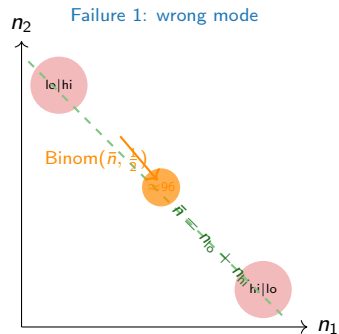
Restriction loses orientation

$\mathcal{R}(n_{lo}, n_{hi}) = n_{lo} + n_{hi} = \mathcal{R}(n_{hi}, n_{lo})$: the **front direction is erased**. $\text{Binom}(\bar{n}, \frac{1}{2})$ places mass at the **unstable** midpoint.

Failure mode 2: bimolecular front ($A+B \rightarrow \emptyset$)

Binomial assumes n_A and n_B are **independent** within a pair. But $A+B \rightarrow \emptyset$ drives them **apart**: a molecule of A and one of B quickly annihilate if they share a sub-voxel.

For strong k_{rxn} , Binomial **overestimates** $P(\text{co-located})$ by $\sim 19\times$, inflating the within-patch



k_{rxn}	$\rho(n_A, n_B)$	$P(\text{co-located})$
0	0.00	76.6% (Binom)
5	-0.80	36.4%
50	-0.98	4.0%

The patch QSD: physics-informed prolongation

One unified fix for both failure modes.

Replace Binomial with the **quasi-stationary distribution (QSD)** of the local patch dynamics:

$$\pi(n_1, \dots, n_M \mid \bar{n}) = \text{QSD of } M\text{-voxel local CME}$$

where the local CME includes internal diffusion *and* reactions within the patch, with reactions that leave the $\bar{n}$ subspace treated as **absorbing** (QSD conditioning).

Generality

M=2 (1D pair) · **M=4** (2D 2×2) · **M=8** (3D 2×2×2).

Works for any CoarseningMap topology.

Precomputed once: one small eigenproblem per $(\bar{n}_A, \bar{n}_B)$.

QSD vs Binomial at the bimolecular front
($d=2$, $\bar{n}_A=\bar{n}_B=3$, varying k_{rxn}):

k_{rxn}	$\rho(n_{A,1}, n_{B,1})$	$P(\text{co-located})$
0	+0.000	76.6%
0.5	-0.095	75.7%
5	-0.796	36.4%
50	-0.982	4.0%

Binomial: always 76.6% (independent assumption).

QSD corrects the $\sim 19\times$ overestimate at strong k_{rxn} — *without any additional runtime cost* beyond the precomputed table.

For covered states, the **multiplicative update**

$$p^{\text{new}}(x) = \tilde{p}(x) \cdot \bar{p}^{\text{post}} / \bar{p}^{\text{pre}} \text{ preserves the fine-level}$$

The V-cycle with conditional prolongation

One V-cycle step:

- 1 **Pre-smooth**: intra-pair diffusion for τ_{pre}
- 2 **Restrict**: $\bar{n}_j = n_{2j-1} + n_{2j}$
- 3 **Recurse**: V-cycle on $K/2$ voxels
- 4 **Prolong**: conditional reconstruction
- 5 **Prune**: remove states with $p(x) < \tau$

Prolongation strategy:

Covered states ($\bar{x} \in \mathcal{R}\tilde{p}$): multiplicative update

$$p^{\text{new}}(x) = \tilde{p}(x) \cdot \frac{\bar{p}^{\text{post}}(\bar{x})}{\bar{p}^{\text{pre}}(\bar{x})}$$

Asymmetry-preserving: mass at $(n_{\text{lo}}, n_{\text{hi}})$ stays there.

New states (expand!-added): use **patch QSD**

$\tilde{p}(\bar{x})$ the within-patch conditional (details)

Why not reconstruct at every step?

Forcing a Binomial split on every pair, every step, erases the within-pair asymmetry (the bistable front).

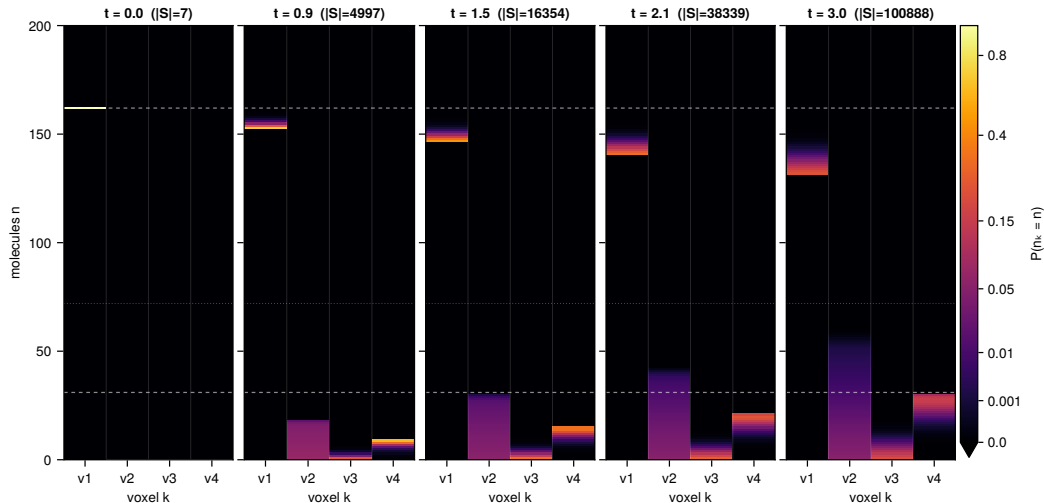
Instead: evolve p^h directly. Coarsening is *only* for the recursive correction; the fine window tracks the true distribution exactly.

Diffusion boundary states ($L_1=2$)

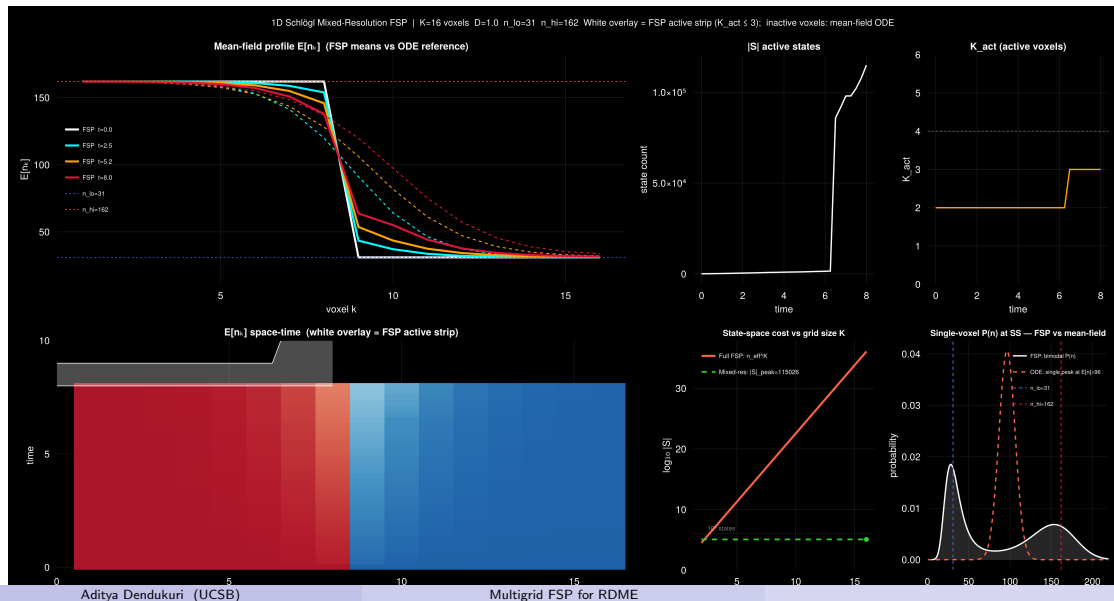
Coarse diffusion $(\bar{n}_1, \bar{n}_2) \rightarrow (\bar{n}_1-1, \bar{n}_2+1)$ is always $L_1=2$. Without this neighbor search, **inter-pair mass transport is invisible** to the V-cycle and molecules never leave pair 1.

Result: Schlögl wavefront spreading via the V-cycle

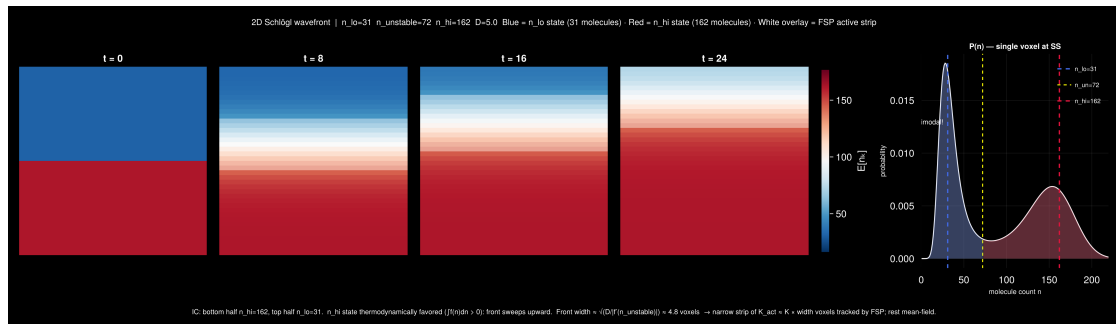
Schlögl RDME: $K=4$, $D=1.0$ — IC: all 162 molecules in v_1 , spreading via diffusion [color: $P^{1/3}$]



Mixed-resolution FSP: adaptive active strip for bistable wavefront



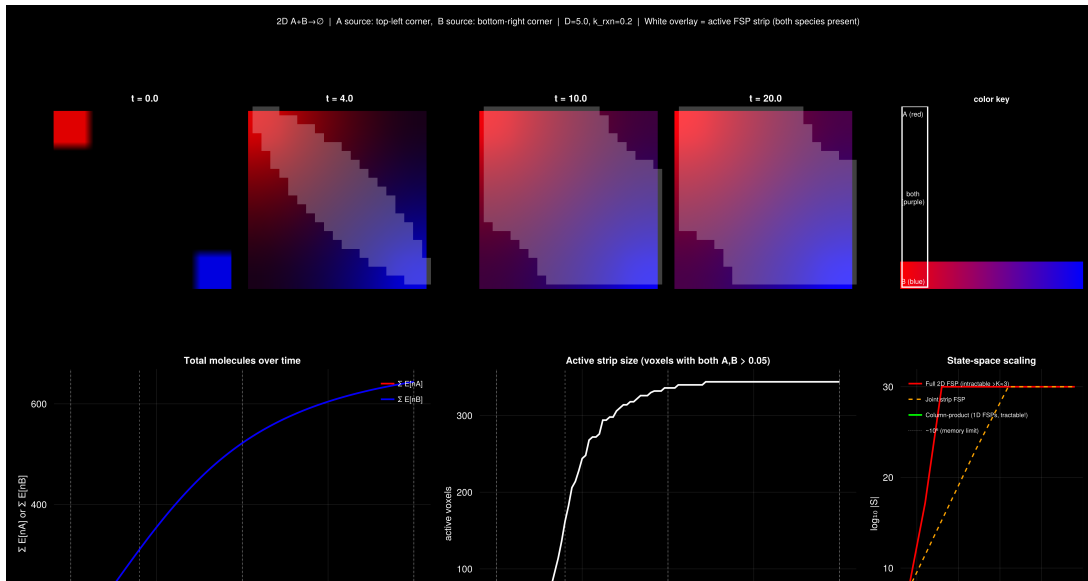
2D Schlögl: bistable front as a spatial wave



Left (4 panels): Mean-field ODE on 40×40 grid. IC: bottom half $n_{hi}=162$ (red), top half $n_{lo}=31$ (blue). $\int f(n) dn > 0$: n_{hi} state thermodynamically favored — front sweeps upward. White overlay = active FSP strip ($n_{lo} < \mu_k < n_{hi}$).

Right panel: Single-voxel stationary distribution $P(n)$. **Bimodal:** mass at $n_{lo}=31$ and $n_{hi}=162$, nothing near $n_{unstable}=72$. Mean-field sees only $E[n]$ — it places a single mode at the current mean and completely misses the two-state structure. **FSP is required at the front to capture this bimodal distribution.** Column-product: each of the K_y columns gets an independent 1D FSP at the front — tractable regardless of K_y .

Two-species $A+B \rightarrow \emptyset$: mixed-resolution reaction front



Summary

1. Restriction + prolongation compresses the RDME state space.

When the within-patch distribution is near-Binomial/Multinomial, marginalizing patches reduces the state space from $n_{\max}^{2S}$ to $n_{\max}^S$ per patch. *K=8 birth-death wavefront solved with 30k states (direct: intractable).*

2. Conditional prolongation handles bistable and bimolecular fronts.

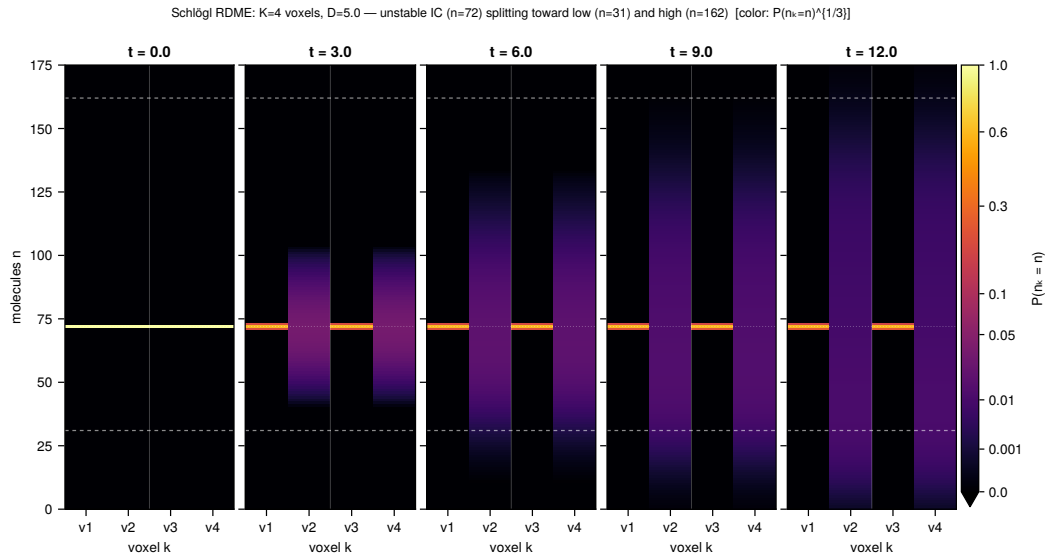
Multiplicative update for covered states preserves within-pair asymmetry. $L_1 \leq 2$ neighbor search propagates both reaction and diffusion boundaries. *Schlögl wavefront and bistable splitting correctly captured.*

3. Mixed-resolution active set: the wavefront is always narrow.

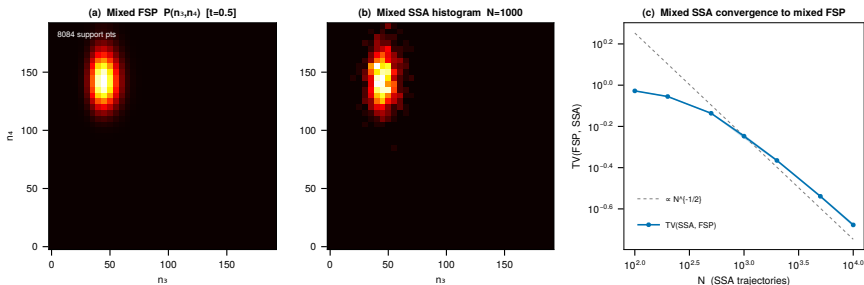
Mean-field for inactive voxels (exact for linear reactions; QSD closure for bimolecular). Adaptive promote/demote keeps $K_{\text{act}} = O(1)$ regardless of K . *$A+B \rightarrow \emptyset$ reaction front tracked in 2D; column-product gives linear scaling in K_y .*

4. Patch QSD: physics-informed prolongation for bimolecular reactions.

Appendix: Schlögl splitting from the unstable fixed point

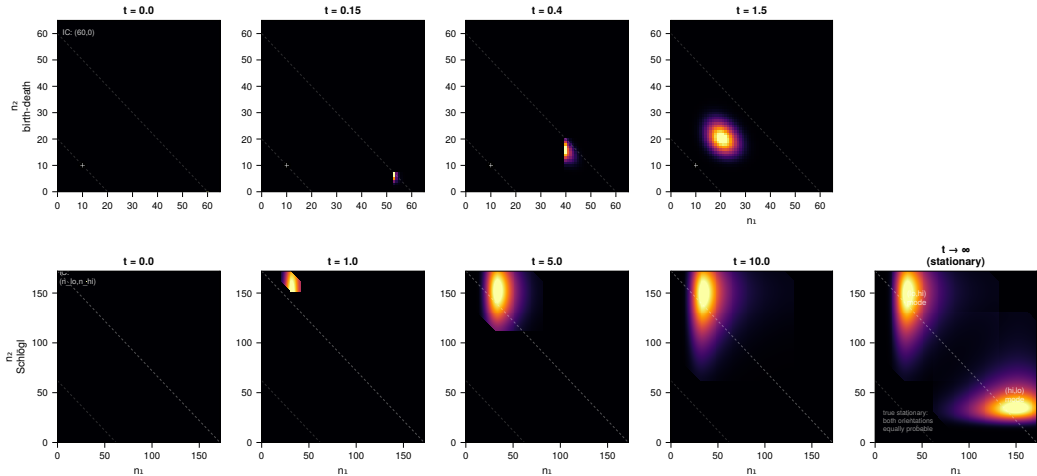


Appendix: mixed-resolution generator self-consistency



ODE solve on the mixed state $(\bar{n}_1, n_3, n_4)$ vs. Monte Carlo on the same reduced generator. Means agree to $<1\%$; $TV \sim N^{-1/2}$ (sampling noise only).

Appendix: probability dynamics (birth-death vs. Schlögl)



Top: birth-death point source traveling to Poisson(10) stationary. Binomial coarsening exact.

Bottom: Schlögl front IC persisting metastably; true stationary (rightmost) shows both orientations equally.

Appendix: K=8 persistent front

